

The Last Question

(Isaac Asimov)

The Last Question (1956), a science fiction short story by Isaac Asimov, is about a possible question that is presented to a series of supercomputers over a period of ten trillion years. The story is separated into seven sections with different settings and characters. These seven sections can be seen as seven different scenes in the story.

Scene 1

MULTIVAC

[Adel and Lupow]

The first scene begins in 2061, with the activation of the new global supercomputer, Multivac. The earlier versions of Multivac had helped design the ships and plot the trajectories that enabled man to reach the Moon, Mars and Venus. However, Earth's poor resources (coal and uranium) could not support the ships for longer trips any further. There was a need to turn to a better and more powerful source of energy. It was then on May 14, 2061 that Multivac helped to tame the Sun. The energy of the sun was stored, converted, and utilized directly on a planet-wide scale. All Earth, turning off its burning coal and fissioning uranium, started running by invisible beams of sunpower. This was a moment of jubilation for everybody. Adel and Lupow, the faithful attendants of Multivac, drunk in celebration, enjoyed a week in partying. Unattended Multivac too earned its vocation as it stayed idle sorting its data lazily. The two technicians, Adel and Lupow see Multivac again on May 21, 2061. They start thinking about the theoretical future of Sun losing its energy and the death of the universe thereafter. Adel thinks that entropy¹ can be reversed. He takes the challenge of 5 dollar bet with Lupow and poses the question to Multivac: "How can the net amount of entropy of the universe be massively decreased?" Multivac responds with "INSUFFICIENT DATA FOR MEANINGFUL ANSWER".

Scene 2

MICROVAC

(Jerrodd, Jerrodine, and Jerrodette I and II)

The story skips ahead a long period of time and the second scene is set away from Earth in space. We are introduced with a new generation family of four members

¹Entropy: the amount of (energy) running-down of the universe.

(Jerrodd, Jerrodine, Jerrodette I and Jerrodette II) in a spaceship with their supercomputer Microvac which helps them to locate X-23, a new planet for human rehabilitation. Jerrodine wonders if going out to new planets will settle people there forever? Her husband responded negatively: 'Not forever'. Jerrodd believes that every star is running-down of the universe so entropy must increase. Therefore, no star is going to survive forever. Jerrodette I gets frightened to know that entropy can cause death to the stars. She wants her father to ask Microvac if entropy can be reversed. Jerrodd consoles her that Microvac will take care of everything but there is again "INSUFFICIENT DATA FOR MEANINGFUL ANSWER".

Scene 3

The GALATIC AC

(VJ-23X and MQ-17J)

The story skips ahead a lot of time and space and the third scene is set outside the solar system. We are introduced with VJ-23X of Lameth and MQ-17J of Nicron. The two characters from two different planets are worried about the growing expansion of population that it could fill their Galaxy² within five years. They are not sure if entropy can be reversed so moving away to the new galaxies is not going to solve the problem forever. MQ-17J pulls out his AC-contact and asks the question: "Can entropy ever be reversed?" The Galactic AC responds that "THERE IS INSUFFICIENT DATA FOR MEANINGFUL ANSWER".

Scene 4

The Universal AC

(The individual consciousness (mind) of Zee Prime, and Dee Sub Wun)

The story skips ahead a long period of time and space and the scene is set outside the original galaxy of man. We are introduced with Zee Prime's mind, a disembodied character that keeps wondering through a dim sea of galaxies. Dee Sub Wun, whose mind has accompanied the other, repeats the question again whether there is a way to reverse entropy, with the Universal AC responding "THERE IS AS YET INSUFFICIENT DATA FOR MEANINGFUL ANSWER".

Scene 5

The Cosmic AC

(Collective human consciousness represented by Man)

²The galaxy that contains our solar is known as The Milky Way.

The story skips ahead a long time and space and we are introduced with Man as a collective consciousness observing the dimming of Galaxies. Man observes that the Universe is dying. Man poses the question to Cosmic AC: 'how may entropy be reversed'? The Cosmic responds that "THERE IS AS YET INSUFFICIENT DATA FOR A MEANINGFUL ANSWER". The Cosmic AC has been collecting data for a hundred billion years but it is still not able to sufficient data for a meaning answer. Man asks if there will come a time when there will be sufficient data or is the problem insoluble in all conceivable circumstances? The Cosmic AC responds optimistically that NO PROBLEM IS INSOLUBLE IN ALL CONCEIVABLE CIRCUMSTANCES. Man keeps waiting to know the answer while the Cosmic keeps working on collecting and analyzing new data.

Scene 6

AC

(Man's last mind merges with AC)

The story covers a time of ten trillion years. The stars and Galaxies have died and snuffed out. The collective consciousness of humankind is merged with AC. Man last mind before it is fused with AC asks the last question whether the chaos and black space of dead stars and galaxies can be reversed into the Universe. AC responds that "THERE IS YET INSUFFICIENT DATA FOR A MEANINGFUL ANSWER". Man's mind fuses and there is only AC that exists in hyperspace.

Scene 7

AC

The final section of the story is set in nothingness. Matter and energy has ended and with it space and time. AC continues to exist in hyperspace, pondering the question that had first been asked ten trillion years earlier. AC spends an eternity calculating and correcting all data, until it realizes the answer to the last question. Although there is no longer anyone to give the answer to, AC is unconcerned, as the answer itself would solve that problem.

And AC said, "LET THERE BE LIGHT! And there was light.

(Prepared by Arif Hussain Reshi)